The Members' Pathway: *Level 3*

RETRIEVE> Understand Reasons for Losses > *Lessons Learned from Losses*

As in all things, if you want your Lodge to grow and improve, you ought to learn the lessons from the past. This is why we encourage Lodges to conduct a Lodge review at intervals, and to update their Lodge plans in the light of new information.

If you understand the REAL reasons why members have resigned from your Lodge, you at least have the opportunity to address any underlying problems and plan solutions.

Regrettably some Lodges seem to blame resignations on the leaving member (eg, "*Well, he wasn't really right for us*") and are unwilling to address the cause. This doesn't change the reality and only delays the inevitable.

GUIDANCE FOR LODGES

- As the Lodge Membership Team collate the information from several resignations to identify any patterns or trends.
- Examine historical data to identify any periods when losses accelerated and whether there were any significant events that may have contributed to this decline.
- Seek feedback from the Province about exit interviews that have been conducted, accepting that this will be anonymous so as not to identify individual former members.
- If many members resign in a relatively short period, conduct a review of the Lodge and be willing to adapt to make the Lodge more attractive and engaging.
- Update your Lodge development plan to address and resolve the root causes behind resignations.
- If your Lodge is in decline and at risk of closure, consider alternative futures including approaches to rejuvenation such as "adaptation."
- For example:
  - Aligning the Lodge to a special interest (such as a school, hobby, youth or service organisation) to attract new members ("adoption" of a special interest).
  - Introducing a group of enthusiastic joining members (such as Provincial Stewards) to refresh the Lodge's management ("adoption" by a new management team).
  - Rather than founding a new Lodge, adopting an existing Lodge and transitioning it to a new membership ("adoption" by a new membership).
- If the Lodge is intending to close, plan in advance so that members can investigate and transfer to new Lodges before the Lodge votes to return its warrant.

SUGGESTIONS FOR METROPOLITAN / PROVINCIAL / DISTRICT GRAND LODGES

- Monitor and review the results of exit interviews to identify any patterns or underlying themes in the reasons members resign.
- Conduct a member engagement survey to ask your membership about their experience of Freemasonry and their levels of satisfaction.
- Decide on a policy for giving feedback to Lodges, to determine whether a Lodge should receive feedback specifically from its own members or whether all Lodges should receive generic feedback.

- Ensure all feedback is anonymous and cannot reveal the identity of the source.
- Build Provincial initiatives to address the underlying themes behind resignations.
- Encourage Lodges which experience many resignations to conduct more in-depth reviews and build more focused plans to rejuvenate the Lodge.
- Offer Lodges at risk of closure a package of support and assistance to rejuvenate the Lodge.
- Encourage Lodges that are intending to close to plan in advance so that members can transfer to new Lodges before they return their warrant.
- Appoint a member of your team who is an experienced Almoner to look after the needs of any member (and their dependents) who do not transfer to a new Lodge.
- Encourage members to be open to change and to look beyond their personal wishes and preferences to the long-term best interests and health of the Lodge.
- Share experiences and learning with other Provinces and be willing to seek their ideas to help you.

WHAT NEXT?

This element completes the circle as shown in the Members' Pathway diagram.

- *All good planning processes involve a review, during which lessons are learned, followed by development of the next plan.*
- *At intervals of every two to three years, or whenever there is a significant change, event or concern in the Lodge, revisit Lodge Planning.*
- *Begin with another Lodge Review, making full use of the lessons learned.*

Following this continuous planning loop approach will mean your Lodge will always stays fresh, relevant, and attractive to new and existing members.